Cargo Hold - Threat Hunt Final Report

Training context: This report documents a simulated LogNPacific cyber-range exercise completed with guided assistance.

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What I investigated

I worked through the alerts and followed the attacker from the first remote login to the final cleanup. I used Microsoft Defender event tables and KQL searches to check logins, process commands, file activity, and registry changes. I matched the accounts, machines, times, and command lines instead of just going off the alerts.

What I found

Getting in and moving around: The already-compromised kenji.sato account connected to azuki-sl from 159.26.106.98. The attacker then used Remote Desktop to reach azuki-fileserver01 (10.1.0.188) and logged in as fileadmin.

Looking around: On the file server, the attacker checked shares and privileges with commands including net share, net view, whoami /all, and ipconfig /all.

Hiding and collecting files: The attacker hid C:\Windows\Logs\CBS with the attrib hidden/system flags, downloaded a script with certutil, and used xcopy to copy four department shares. The copied material included IT-Admin-Passwords.csv. Three staged folders were compressed using tar.

Sending data out: I found curl commands sending four staged files to file.io. This is strong evidence of an attempted data theft, and the hunt briefing describes the uploads as completed.

Staying in and covering tracks: The attacker added a Run-key value named FileShareSync to launch the disguised script svchost.ps1. A renamed dump tool, pd.exe, targeted LSASS memory. Afterward, six Windows event logs were cleared, starting with Security, and the PowerShell history file ConsoleHost_history.txt was deleted.

My assessment

This was not normal system maintenance. The same account and server show a clear chain of unauthorized access, discovery, bulk file collection, outbound uploads, persistence, credential dumping, and evidence removal. The password file and LSASS dump make the possible credential exposure especially serious.

What I would recommend

I would isolate the affected file server, disable or reset the compromised accounts, rotate any exposed credentials, remove the Run-key persistence and script, and review outbound traffic and the uploaded files. I would also check neighboring machines for the same indicators, preserve available evidence, and tighten remote-access controls and monitoring.

Bottom line: I was able to follow the attack step by step in the logs and tie the activity together with the actual commands and file paths.